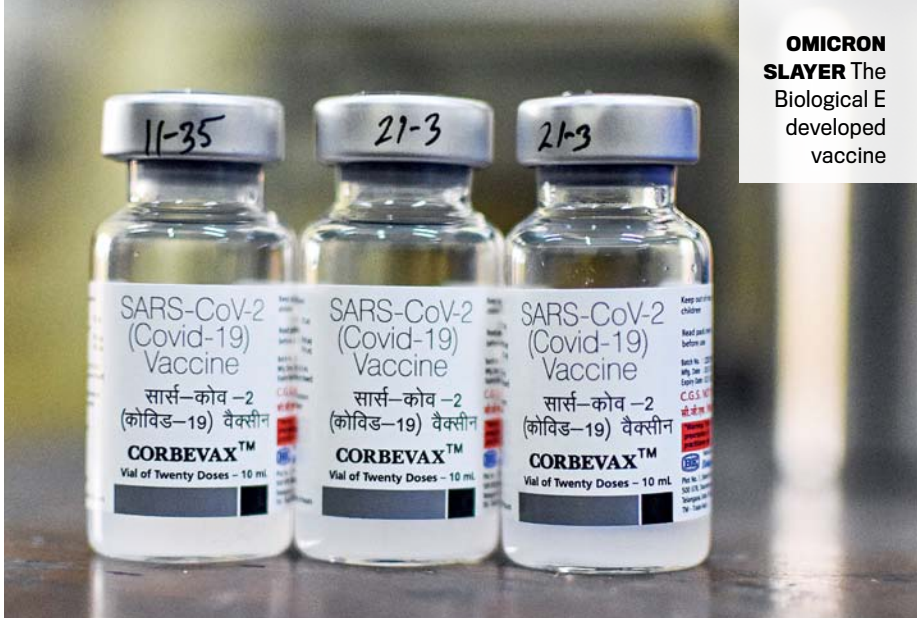
hiana, Jalandhar, Amritsar and Jammu—for nearly three weeks during holiday season. The unions had been disbanded in 2017 after the then Congress regime introduced the Punjab Goods Carriages (Regulation and Prevention of Cartelisation Rules), 2017. The protest was suspended on January 7 after the AAP government agreed to constitute an 11-member committee—comprising four trucker representatives, four government nominees and three industrialists—by month-end. The truckers warn the blockade will resume if their demands are not met by then.

The teaching fraternity seems disillusioned with the AAP regime too. The New Year began with the joint action committee of various unions representing teachers, other employees and pensioners of government-aided schools in Punjab threatening to 'gherao' Mann's residence over the government's failure to extend the benefits of the Sixth Pay Commission to them. The AAP government merely cites the state's poor fiscal situation as the reason for its helplessness.

Before taking over the state's reins, Mann was regularly seen at protest sites, using his satirical comedy to win over union leaders and members. Many saw him as a comrade. Now these unions expect the comedian-turned-CM to deliver on his promises. On January 5, Punjab agriculture minister Kuldeep Singh Dhaliwal listed the various "pro-farmer" decisions taken by the Mann government in its 10-month rule—including minimum support price (MSP) for moong dal and jobs to the next of kin of farmers who died during the year-long agitation on the Delhi borders. But the protesting farmers were unimpressed. It's a curious role reversal for a party that revels in taking up populist stances and, going by Punjab's mood, it will need to navigate carefully between flexibility and firmness. ■



AFP

OMICRON SLAYER The Biological E developed vaccine

COVID VACCINE

DOES INDIA NEED A FOURTH DOSE?

By Sonali Acharjee

COVID-19 is not becoming just a bad memory yet, it seems. On January 10, India reported a fresh case of the XBB 1.5 sub-variant, nicknamed the Kraken variant, pushing India's total cases to eight. The strain combines mutations from two Omicron variants—BA.2.10.1 and BA.2.75—and is also fuelling the latest surge in the US. Meanwhile, India has also recorded several cases of the BF.7 Omicron sub-variant, many found in the samples of Covid-positive international visitors, and fuelling the current wave in China. However, despite the entry of these two new sub-variants, which have caused both increased infection and death in other countries, India is currently in a comfortable position. On January 9, only one death and 121 new cases were reported. Countrywide, India has less than 2,500 active cases at present.

The low case load, of course, could be because people are not getting themselves tested, or having asymptomatic runs. The country's extensive vaccination programme, under which almost all of India's adult population has been immunised, is also why we are faring better than the rest of the world. "Vaccines are the key to our defence against Covid," says Dr N.K. Arora, head of the National Technical Advisory Group on Immunisation (NTAGI). "They give our immune systems the boost needed to prevent serious infection." A survey published in the January 2023 edition of the *Nature Medicine* journal found 98 per cent Indians accepting Covid vaccines, substantially higher than the global average of 79 per cent.

Doctors say a fourth dose may not help unless it's of a vaccine that can prevent infection

However, where India has faltered is in its intake of the booster dose. Only 28 per cent of the eligible population has taken it. The coverage has been so low in West Bengal that around 80,000 Covaxin